

Indian Ocean

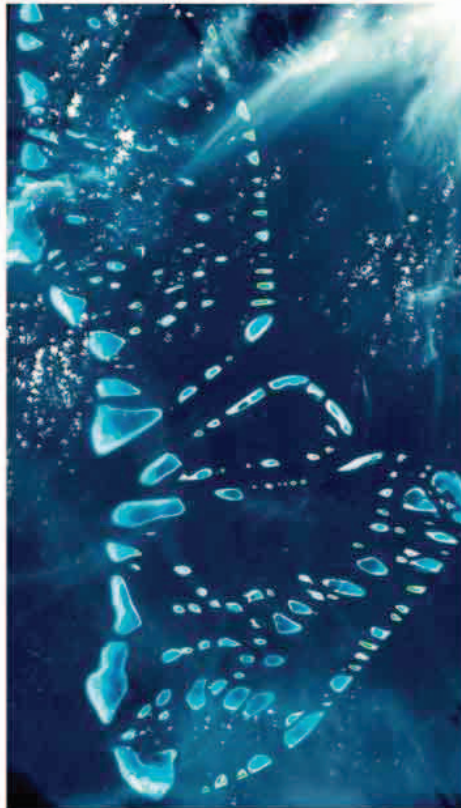
Unlike the Atlantic and Pacific oceans, the Indian Ocean does not extend far north of the equator. Most of its waters are tropical, aside from in the far south. The deep Java Trench on its eastern margin is one of the world's most active earthquake zones, causing catastrophic tsunamis.



FACT FILE

Area:	28,400,000 sq miles (73,600,000 sq km)
Average depth:	12,760 ft (3,890 m)
Deepest point:	24,440 ft (7,450 m)

Island jewels



To the south of India, a submerged ridge of rock is capped with the ring-shaped coral atolls of the Maldives. Each atoll is formed of many smaller atolls, and from high above the ocean, they look like strings of pearls. These low-lying islands are vulnerable to tsunamis, and are at risk from rising sea levels.

New oceans



▲ RED SEA

This sea may owe its name to the blooms of red algae that sometimes form on its surface. Usually, its water is a vivid, glittering blue.

The Red Sea between Africa and Saudi Arabia is a spreading rift in Earth's crust that is getting wider every year. In the distant future, it will become a new ocean. The rift extends south through East Africa, and this will probably open up to form a new sea.

Monsoon winds

Over most oceans, the wind blows from the same direction all year round. But in the northern Indian Ocean, the wind blows from the dry northeast in winter, and from the rainy southwest in summer. This seasonal wind change is called a monsoon.



▲ THIRD LARGEST OCEAN

From South Africa to its eastern boundary on the southern tip of Australia, the Indian Ocean is almost 6,200 miles (10,000 km) wide. To its south, it meets the cold, stormy waters of the Southern Ocean.

